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India has one of the world's oldest and richest histories, with roots extending back to the Indus Valley Civilization around 2500 BCE. This civilization, located along the Indus River, featured advanced urban planning, drainage systems, and trade networks, indicating a highly organized society. Notable cities like Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro reflect the achievements of this early culture.

Following the decline of the Indus Valley Civilization, the Vedic period (circa 1500 BCE - 500 BCE) marked the arrival of Indo-Aryans. This era saw the composition of the Vedas, ancient texts that remain central to Hindu philosophy and religious practices. The caste system began to take shape during this time, and early kingdoms and tribal communities emerged across the Indian subcontinent.

The rise of powerful kingdoms and empires followed, including the Maurya Empire (322 BCE - 185 BCE). Under Emperor Ashoka, the Maurya Empire reached its peak, covering much of the Indian subcontinent. Ashoka embraced Buddhism after the bloody Kalinga War and played a key role in spreading Buddhist teachings throughout Asia.

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After the Mauryas, the Gupta Empire (circa 320 CE - 550 CE) ushered in a "Golden Age" of art, science, mathematics, and literature. During this period, scholars like Aryabhata made significant contributions to astronomy and mathematics, and classical Sanskrit literature flourished.

The medieval period witnessed the rise of regional kingdoms and the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate (1206 CE - 1526 CE). This era brought cultural exchanges, new architectural styles, and the spread of Islam in India. The Mughal Empire followed, starting with Babur's victory in 1526 CE. Under rulers like Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan, and Aurangzeb, the Mughal Empire expanded and left a legacy of stunning architecture, including the Taj Mahal.

By the 18th century, European colonial powers, especially the British, began to dominate. The British East India Company gradually gained control, leading to direct British rule after the Revolt of 1857. India's struggle for independence, led by figures like Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, culminated in freedom from British rule on August 15, 1947. Today, India stands as the world's largest democracy, shaped by a complex and vibrant history spanning thousands of years.